

# Assyrian fortifications and temples

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The Assyrians (c.2500–539 BCE) were a warlike people for whom city fortifications served both a defensive and an ideological role: massive walls, representing the king's power, bore sculpted surfaces that displayed victories over enemies. The city of Nimrud boasted a palace set in vast courtyards, a ziggurat, the temple of Ezida and a huge encircling wall studded with towers. The final capital of the Assyrian Empire was the city of Nineveh (opposite), founded c.700 BCE on the Tigris River opposite the site of modern-day Mosul. King Sennacherib built a 12-kilometre (7.5-mile) brick wall around it with 15 towering gates, each named after an Assyrian god and each flanked by square towers with parapets and battlements.

Assyrians were a polytheistic people with a powerful priestly class. Their cities contained temples where their main gods were revered; as in Egyptian temples, gods were believed to live in sacred areas where only the priests could enter, and each god was represented by a specific statue in the temple.

